OTHER DISADVANTAGED GROUPS

YSR BIMA

Grant to families of unorganised workers in the event of accidental death or disability

Beneficiaries 103,171; Spend Rs 1,681.93 cr

SPECIAL COVID AID

Rs 10,000 to all white card holders to cope with the hardships posed by the Covid-19 pandemic

Beneficiaries 13,505,338; Spend Rs 1350.53 cr

AGRIGOLD

Rs 10,000-20,000 as a mitigating measure to small depositors in the Agrigold deposit scheme that went bust

Beneficiaries 1,040,000; Spend Rs 905.57 cr

JAGANANNA THODU

Rs 10,000 interest-free loan through banks to poor traders, cart traders and traditional artisans to meet their financial needs

Beneficiaries 905,458; Spend Rs 905 cr

YSR VAHANA MITRA

Rs 10,000 a year to self - owned autorickshaw, taxi and maxi cab drivers for upkeep of their vehicle

Beneficiaries 274,015; Spend Rs 762.42 cr

YSR NETHANNA NESTHAM

Rs 24,000 a year to every eligible handloom weaver's family owning a loom

Beneficiaries 81,703; Spend Rs 575.87 cr

YSR MATSYAKARA BHAROSA

Rs 10,000 a year to fishermen families during the fishing ban period

Beneficiaries 119,875 ; Spend Rs 331.58 cr

JAGANANNA CHEDODU

Rs 10,000 a year towards investment for washermen, barbers and tailors who lost livelihood opportunities because of the Covid pandemic

Beneficiaries 298,428; Spend Rs 298.43 cr

PRIESTS, IMAMS AND PASTORS SCHEME

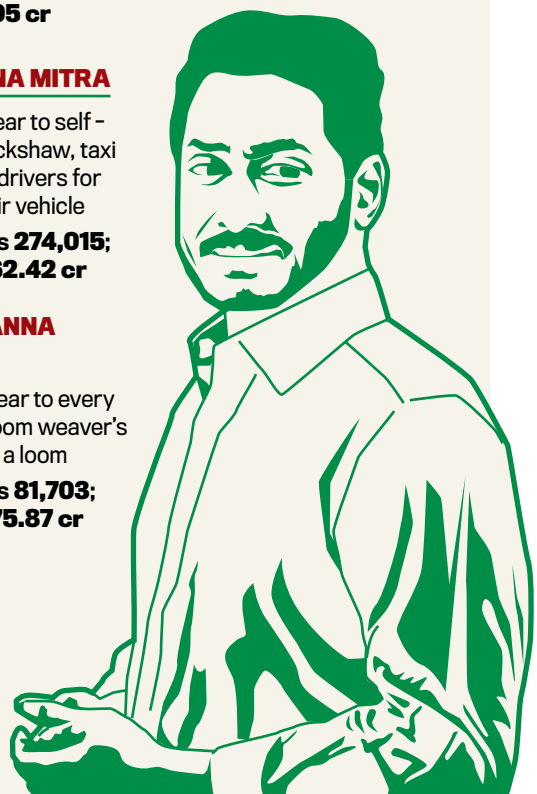
Rs 5,000 as a one-time grant to priests of all religious persuasions in view of the adverse impact of Covid-19

Beneficiaries 77,290; Spend Rs 37.71 cr

YSR LAW NESTHAM

Rs 5,000 a month as stipend for first three years to junior lawyers starting out

Beneficiaries 2,012; Spend Rs 13.08 cr



bonds at auction at a seven per cent interest (higher than the bids of four other states). State government employees and pensioners are a restive lot after the delays in salaries and pensions. To win over government staff, Jagan announced a fitment of 23 per cent (against the recommended 14.3 per cent) in their earnings on January 7, and showered a slew of other gains, including housing plots, compassionate appointments and clearing of pending dearness allowances. This will cost the already cash-strapped government another Rs 10,247 crore a year. Jagan Mohan has also raised the retirement age to 62 from 60. Despite this, the employees are threatening a strike from February 7.

"The slide started in 2018 with Naidu's Rs 9,400 crore Pasupu Kumkuma scheme, which provided a grant of Rs 10,000 each to women in self-help groups," rues former revenue minister D.L. Ravindra Reddy. "The state is heading towards bankruptcy. We spend every paisa on revenue expenditure (expenses to meet ongoing operational costs) when at least 30 per cent of the funds should be earmarked for capital expenditure and asset building."

In the first half of the 2021-22 financial year, revenue deficit rose by an unprecedented 662.8 per cent while the fiscal deficit climbed up by 107.8 per cent. The state had projected a revenue deficit of Rs 5,000.1 crore fo the year butit shot up to Rs 33,140.6 crore in the April-September period itself. About half of the total earnings of Rs 1.05 lakh crore have been used for welfare schemes, according to the CAG accounts for the first half of the year. This is more than the Rs 48,083.9 crore Rajendranath's budget had provisioned for the whole year, and includes Rs 39,914.2 crore in borrowings (which have also breached the target for the whole year). Analysts say the state is shifting goalposts to cover up the crisis. On November 26, the Jagan government amended the Fiscal Responsbility and Budget Management (FRBM) Act, 2005, to enable enhanced borrowings and also allow a larger revenue deficit. "Covid-19 has caused a substantial reduction in realisation of revenues. Horizontal devolution of central transfers has also reduced in the 15th Finance Commission award. These constraints compounded our fiscal stress," says Rajendranath, justifying the amendments to the FRBM Act. Yanamala Ramakrishnudu, former finance minister and leader of the opposition in the state legislative council, wants "a thorough probe into the reckless spending".

DEEPENING CRISIS

THE YSRC HAS TAKEN REVENUE expenditure to unprecedented levels. A staggering 66.12 million beneficiaries have got a total of Rs 1.12 lakh crore through the slew of direct benefit transfer (DBT) schemes and doles since June 2019. And Jagan is still tweaking welfare schemes based on feedback. The Jagananna Vidya Deevena, aimed at reimbursing the fees of poor students, has led to increasing